

RUSSIAN WINE  
TASTING — SPEAKING NOTES

SIX WINES · PHUKET · 29 AUGUST 2026

WINE 1 OF 6 SPARKLING · TRADITIONAL METHOD

## VICTOR DRAVIGNY BRUT

Abrau-Durso · Krasnodar region, Russia

Say it: ah-BRAU DOOR-so · dra-vee-NYI

Our first wine comes from Russia.

The winery is called Abrau-Durso. If you ask any Russian to name one wine brand, this is the name they say. It is the most famous one in the country. And they are famous first of all for sparkling wine.

The winery is in the south of Russia, in the Krasnodar region. It stands right next to a lake — Lake Abrau — in the mountains. A very beautiful place.

This wine is called Victor Dravigny. That was a real person: a French champagne master. He came to Abrau-Durso and started making sparkling wine here the traditional way — the same way they make Champagne in France. Today this is one of the top lines of the winery, and it carries his name.

**Traditional method** means the wine finishes fermenting **inside this bottle**, not in a big tank. Then the bottle just rests. This one rested for **two years**, in old tunnels inside the mountain.

Abrau-Durso became the official supplier to the Russian Emperor, **Nicholas the Second**. So this is the wine of the tsar.

Three grapes inside: **Riesling, Chardonnay and Pinot Blanc**.

The taste is fresh and clean, with light fruit. Fine small bubbles. Very easy to drink. — **Enjoy!**

# ARISTOV RIESLING

Taman Peninsula · Kuban, Russia

Say it: ah-REE-stov · tah-MAHN · REES-ling

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That was the classic — the imperial wine. Now let's see what young Russia is doing.

The winery is called Aristov. It is a young winery — not two hundred years of history like the first one. But they are serious about quality. They make sparkling wines and white wines, a small good line-up.

They are on the Taman Peninsula, in the Kuban region. That is the very south of Russia, between two seas — the Black Sea and the Sea of Azov. A lot of sun, and the sea keeps the nights cool. Very good for white grapes.

This wine is made from **Riesling**. The vines are young — about **five years old**.

And this wine has **no oak, no aging**. Straight from the tank to the bottle. So what you taste is only the grape and the place. Nothing hiding it.

Smell it first. You will find **citrus** — lemon, a little grapefruit. Then **flowers**, white flowers. And at the end something like wet stone — we call it **mineral**.

The taste is balanced: not too sweet, not too sharp. Clean and dry.

This is a wine for hot weather and for food. Very good with seafood — and it works with **Thai food** too, because it is fresh and it cools the mouth.

# CHÂTEAU TAMAGNE CHARDONNAY

Taman Peninsula · Kuban, Russia

Say it: sha-TOH ta-MAHN · shar-do-NAY

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Wine number three. White again, and again from the Taman Peninsula — the same sunny corner of southern Russia.

This one is Château Tamagne. A big, strong producer. They make a lot of different wines, and they have been doing it for a long time. When you see this name in Russia, you know what you are buying.

And this is **Chardonnay** — probably the most famous white grape in the world. You know it from France, from Australia, from California.

One nice detail. The last wine came from young vines, five years old. This one comes from vines that are **twenty-three years old**. Old vines give less fruit, but the fruit is more concentrated. The wine has more to say.

Now — an important comparison. Many people know Chardonnay from America. American Chardonnay is usually **buttery** — you really taste butter, vanilla, cream. That comes from the oak barrels.

This one is not that style. This is a **lighter** Chardonnay. **Flowers and fruit**, fresh, easy. You can drink a glass and you don't feel heavy.

So if someone tells you "I don't like Chardonnay, it's too heavy" — **this is the wine to give them.**

# CHÂTEAU TAMAGNE SIGNATURE — SAPERAVI

Taman Peninsula · Kuban, Russia

Say it: SIG-na-cher · sa-pe-RAH-vee

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And now, finally, something red.

Same producer as the last wine — Château Tamagne — but a different line. This one is called Signature. Signature is their aged line. Every wine in it spends time in oak barrels. This is the serious shelf.

The grape is **Saperavi**. Vintage **2023**.

Saperavi is special. In almost every red grape, only the skin is red and the juice inside is clear. In Saperavi, **the juice is red too**. That is why the colour is so strong — look at your glass, it goes from bright ruby to deep dark ruby.

This wine spent **at least one year in oak**. What does the barrel do? Wood is not perfectly closed — a very small amount of oxygen comes through. The wine breathes, slowly. It softens, and it takes flavour from the wood.

The oak also gives **tannins**. Tannin is not a taste, it is a feeling — that dry feeling on your tongue, like strong tea. Here the tannins are there, but they are **balanced**. Soft, not aggressive.

The taste: **black berries** and dark fruit. A **creamy, dairy note** — some people say cheese. And in the end, a little note of **leather**. That is the oak and the age talking. Full and velvety in the mouth.

This is the wine for meat, for grill, for a long evening.

# CHÂTEAU TAMAGNE NU — SAPERAVI

Taman Peninsula · Kuban, Russia

| Say it: NEW · sa-pe-RAH-vee | keep the previous glass — we compare

Wine number five. Saperavi again — but forget everything about the last glass. This is the same grape treated in a completely different way. Keep your other glass, we will compare.

This line is called NU. In French, “nu” means **naked**. And that is exactly the idea: wine with nothing on it. No make-up.

This is the most **natural** wine in the whole range — what people call **minimal intervention**. The winemaker does as little as possible and lets the wine do the work.

Normally a winery filters the wine to make it clear — sometimes twice, with machines and pressure. Here there is **no second filtering**. Instead they use something free: **gravity**.

The wine just stands still. Slowly, all the small particles fall down to the bottom by themselves. The clear wine stays on top, and that is what goes into the bottle. It takes patience — but nothing is stripped out of the wine.

And that is the point. When you filter hard, you take out the cloudiness — but you also take out some of the flavour. Here, everything stays inside.

So the taste is the **brightest and the most intense** of the evening. **Dark berries. Ripe fruit.** Loud, alive, a little wild.

One small thing: if you see a tiny bit of sediment in the glass — that is not a problem. That is the wine being honest with you.

Same grape as before, **two different worlds**.

# ABRAU-DURSO PINOT NOIR

Abrau-Durso · Krasnodar region, Russia · Limited series

Say it: ah-BRAU DOOR-so · PEE-no NWAR

And for the finish — the most special bottle of the evening. And look: we are going back to where we started. Abrau-Durso again — the same winery as our first glass. But this time, no bubbles.

This is Pinot Noir. Before we drink it, let me tell you why this grape matters.

Pinot Noir is a **difficult** grape. Thin skin, gets sick easily, hates hot weather, small crop. Most winemakers avoid it. You can find a lot of Pinot Noir in the world, and honestly, most of it is not very good.

But when someone gets it right — **Pinot Noir makes the most expensive wine in the world**. Not Cabernet. Not Merlot. Pinot Noir. The famous wines of Burgundy in France, the bottles that sell for thousands of dollars — this grape.

So Pinot Noir is a test. It shows you immediately if the winemaker is good or not.

And that is why this bottle is interesting. This is a **limited series** from Abrau-Durso — one of the most serious attempts to work with Pinot Noir in Russia. Not much of it exists. It is aged in **French oak barrels, at least nine months**.

What to look for. First, **ripe dark fruit** — blackberry, and prune, dark and sweet. Then something deeper: a little **tobacco**. And the classic Pinot Noir smell — the forest. **Wet leaves, earth after rain**. In wine we call it “forest floor”. Once you find it, you will never forget it.

The taste is juicy, not heavy. Elegant. This is the top of the range. And this is our last glass — so take your time with it.

**Thank you all for coming tonight.** Six wines, one country — and we finish in the same place we started. A lot of history in the glass. Enjoy!